

Adam Hickey

Independent product designer · Strategy · UX · Design systems · Prototyping · Build

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Professional summary

Independent product designer with 20 years in complicated enterprise software, for organizations like Cargill, Intel, CBRE and Toro. I untangle complex products, decide what is worth building, and turn it into something people can actually use. Most of the last decade went to design systems: auditing them for structural gaps, building the tokens and component architecture underneath, and writing the governance that keeps them alive after the engagement ends. I use AI to scale the system rather than just my own output, and I document systems so that people and AI tools read the same rules. The judgment calls stay human.

Experience

Independent Practice — Product Design

2026 – Present

- Product definition, design, systems and prototyping for complicated software, from ambiguity through to something a team can react to, in fixed-scope, timeboxed engagements.
- Door County Found — a regional travel guide where every place is structured data rather than a blog post. Defined, designed and built end to end, including the editing workflow.

RBA Inc — Lead UX Product Designer

2013 – 2026

- Led enterprise product design and UX strategy for clients in manufacturing, healthcare, financial services, and the public sector, including compliance-sensitive work for a federal agency, a regional bank and healthcare providers.
- Tied design decisions to the numbers product, engineering and business teams already track: efficiency, adoption, quality, ROI.
- Built and governed design systems across SAP, Microsoft, Umbraco, and Sitecore platforms: tokens, component libraries, contribution rules and release checkpoints. Led accessibility, DesignOps and governance practices.
- Used AI to scale the design system: drafting documentation, auditing for drift, checking design against code, and pulling research together. Human judgment on every decision.

Selected projects

- Scaling enterprise product design across 40+ SAP applications: one design system and accessibility standard, about a third less time from design to development, and UI defects in production cut by more than half.
- Sprout, a design system for Cargill: tokens in the code, mirrored as Figma variables under a written sync contract, and packaged as a Claude Code skill so AI tools build from the same source of truth.
- Cutting operational overhead 80% with a USDA grant-management portal (research, workflows, accessibility).
- Orchestrating real-time logistics for a 450+ truck fleet (cockpit UI, fleet visibility, dispatcher workflows).

Core capabilities

Product Strategy · UX & Interaction Design · Design Systems & Token Architecture · Design System Governance & Documentation · AI-Assisted Design & Development · Rapid Prototyping · Front-End Build · Research & Synthesis · Information Architecture · Accessibility

Design tools & platforms

Figma/FigJam (variables, Dev Mode, component libraries) · Claude & Claude Code (skills, plugins, MCP) · ChatGPT · Gemini · CSS custom properties (tokens) · HTML/CSS/JavaScript · Astro · Playwright · Git/GitHub · Adobe Creative Suite · SAP Fiori · Sitecore · Umbraco · SharePoint · Power BI · WCAG 2.1 AA

Education

Bachelor of Science in Graphic Design, University of Minnesota–Twin Cities (2005)

Prior professional experience

Pixel Farm — Interactive Designer / Developer

Jan 2008 – Apr 2013

- Designed and shipped two native iOS apps and an iPad app, including a centennial app for Dorsey & Whitney.
- Built the “Build Your Boat” configurator for Lund Boats and a custom store-locator integration for Fulton Beer.
- Built front-end experiences in HTML, CSS, and jQuery across Joomla! and WordPress; led rebrands and visual identity systems.

LEVEL — Interactive Designer

Jan 2006 – Jan 2008

Designed and built front-end websites in HTML, CSS, and Flash with project managers, creative leads, writers, and developers.

ByDesign — Graphic Designer

Jan 2005 – Jan 2006

In-house creative for University of Minnesota and Twin Cities clients; led a small team producing Flash games and digital assets.